

Text One

How to Empower Students to Create Change

adapted from an article by Leigh Ann Whittle

In this passage, the writer advises teachers about how to encourage their students to participate in social change campaigns.



It is a great mistake to assume that social change can only be achieved by those who have already reached adulthood. In fact, many young people are transforming their world in ways that put adults to shame. As a teacher, you can be the inspiration to help our young people continue to change the world for the better.

Examples of social change are plentiful

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A recent article highlights kids who are challenging social attitudes, raising money for people they have never encountered and speaking out about horrors that they may never experience.

It offers several inspiring examples, one of which is that of Rhode Island high school student Grace Miner, who formed *Real Girls Matter* to discuss how the media negatively portrays girls. It's not just older students who are making a difference. Florida teen Joshua Williams formed *Joshua's Heart* to feed the hungry in the Miami area; he first gave money to the hungry at age six. Seven-year-old Ryan Hreljac bought a well in Uganda and continues to raise money to build wells in Africa many years later.

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Clearly, students are capable of social change. The key is to help them turn the negativity in their lives or someone else's into a positive, teach them that the world is much bigger than their own environment, and help them find their voice. Often this can be done through technology, real-world experiences, and offering them opportunities for choice and responsibility. 15

Offer them a choice and a voice 20

It is true that young people need rules and structure to guide them. But if we make their lives *only* about the rules, how can we expect them to emerge into adulthood fully capable of making their own decisions? The bottom line is that students need to be placed into situations requiring a decision. Offering them small decisions so that they gain a better understanding of the decision-making process will build their confidence, which in turn will help them better prepare to take on larger decisions – and, ultimately, to feel confident in making a real impact on the larger world around them. 25

You should actively seek their opinions on topics, demonstrating to them that they have something valuable to say. 30

Use technology effectively

Showing students that they have a voice that deserves to be heard empowers young people to do more and offers a fresh perspective on many social issues – and technology can and should be an important part of this. It will provide a safe testing ground for your students to express their most deeply held views on a public platform, while also listening to other voices that may be far outside their perspectives. 35

One key lesson that students can learn about technology is its effectiveness in making social change a widespread phenomenon. No doubt students are familiar with popular socially-minded hashtags and viral sensations such as the Ice Bucket Challenge (a phenomenon in the summer of 2014 in which people poured a bucket of iced water over their heads in order to get donations to charities before nominating others to do the same), which raised more than \$100 million. That challenge alone was the creation of one individual and showed how one person can single-handedly prompt successful social change. 40

In this way, today's technology can be effectively used to widen your students' conceptions of what is and isn't possible in terms of social change. That in itself is a powerful lesson on its own, but you can take this further by encouraging students to use these experiences as a launching-off point for their own initiatives. Why not, for example, have the class choose a cause they're passionate about and then come up with an idea for a video that could go viral to rival that of the Ice Bucket Challenge? The possibilities are endless when you pair a good cause with a little creative thinking. 45 50

Connect real life to the classroom

Classes should not be taught in a bubble. Bring in real world events to demonstrate connections between what is going on in students' lives and the learning material. Ask students to offer their opinions on these current situations and devise solutions to the social problems that affect them personally, as well as society at large. Exposing them to social issues raises awareness of what is going on beyond the school doors and prompts action. Students become more engaged with the world and more capable of generating ideas on how to implement change. 55

Hold them accountable

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It's one thing to dream big about making a global impact, and another thing entirely to take responsibility, have follow-up and follow-through, and actually do it. Accountability reinforces to students that someone else is watching them and that what they do does matter.

In short

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Kids can bring about social change, perhaps even more effectively than adults can. Through choice, technology, real-world scenarios, and accountability, we can empower our students continually to grow and improve themselves and the world around them.

Text Two

Making a Difference - Youth Participation

adapted from a talk by Ellie Jones

In this passage, Ellie Jones speaks about how young people can participate in local and international social and community projects.



Ellie Jones was awarded the Diana Anti-bullying Champion Award in 2010 for her work with the charity, *Changing Faces*. This charity supports young people living with a facial disfigurement and works to tackle appearance-based discrimination.

Over the past four years, Ellie has become even more passionate about changing our society for the better. At the age of 16, she spoke at a Diana Award event at the House of Lords in London, about the important part that young people have to play in society today. She is passionate about youth voice and participation to ensure that young people have access to opportunities to change their communities.

'I am involved with quite a lot of projects at the Diana Award. The Diana Award is an organisation which works to recognise and support young people who are doing really positive things in their communities. Supporting projects like *Changing Faces* is really important because, again, it's about the reputation of young people in society. Often there is this idea that we're destructive, that we don't contribute anything positive, that we don't care about other people. So getting involved with these projects means that young people have the opportunity to show that we can do really positive things and that we do want to make a change in our society, that we do want to act as responsible citizens, that we do really want to start making changes and we want to be taking responsibility in our communities.'

I would say the main barrier for young people trying to get our message across is the fact that, for us, sometimes it can feel really hopeless because there is such a negative attitude surrounding young people in our society, in this country today. I think that often it feels like everyone expects us to be destroying society and contributing negatively, rather than positively. In some ways, this is a self-fulfilling prophecy because we feel like we're expected to be doing all these negative things. So we feel like there is no point trying to help society, or trying to contribute anything positive because no one is ever going to really accept that. I think that's the main barrier of young people's attitudes towards their own potential and so, if we feel like we can do positive things, then that's when people really start to get out there and start to get involved. Whereas if you feel hopeless, it seems as if there is no point in even trying. 20 25

I think that all young people definitely have an incredible, incredible potential to contribute positively in their communities. Charities like the Diana Award are really about making sure that all young people have the opportunity to do that. So it's really about challenging the perception of young people as being destructive to society and shining a spotlight on those young people who are looking to improve their communities, both locally and across the UK. 30 35

My message for young people who want to get involved in society is: don't be scared. I think that young people have a lot more power than they realise. It is really about having courage and standing up and saying "Look, this is what's important to us. This is what we want to change." So I guess the main message that I would have to give is: don't stop screaming until they hear you. Keep on making the effort - sometimes it will feel like you're ramming your head into a brick wall, but eventually you can get there if you persevere and if you have courage and if you keep striving towards the things that are important to you. Then eventually you will get there and eventually you will be able to make that positive change. So, stick with it. 40

It's about getting the most out of your time as a young person and about seeing what all of us can contribute together. My message to young people, who want to get involved in society, is that there's nothing really that is a greater barrier than being worried about what people think about you or worried that you won't succeed. Even the fact that you want to get involved in society is a massive step forward. It really shows that you can be a responsible member of our society, and that you care, and that you can be compassionate, and that you can really focus on making a difference to the lives of others. I would say don't be afraid, don't worry about whether you are going to succeed, because any change at all that you manage to make, no matter how small, can make a massive difference to someone else's life. So have courage.' 45 50